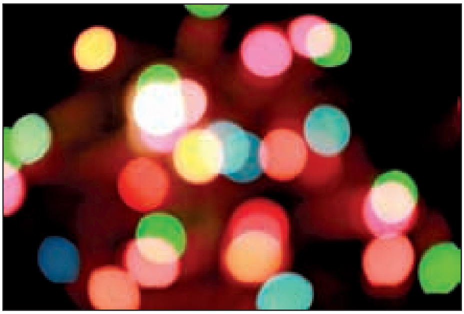
rior optical image quality than the zoom lens. Also, below f/2 there are no commercially available zoom lenses, and almost all prime lenses at least open up to f/1.8 (some open up to f/1.4 and beyond) giving you the ability to shoot in very low light and much more artistic freedom. Sharpness available at almost all aperture ranges and the bokeh effect is matchless when compared to zoom lenses.


Bokeh from a prime lens

Other advantage of prime lenses come in the form of weight and speed. An inexpensive prime lens can generally provide as good (or better) image quality as a high-end zoom lens. Some prime lenses such as the Nikon 35mm f/1.8 offer rear focus control, ie the focussing ring does not come in the way of your filter or polariser (refer to the chapter on lens filters). This ensures that the polariser stays exactly as put.

Some people also use prime lenses as a budget macro lens with the use of reversal link.

Prime lenses, especially, excel in portrait and indoor photography as the light is limited and you want precise control of depth of field. The narrow depth of field in a portrait helps isolate the subject from its background. On lower end dSLRs, these lens also provide a much brighter image in the viewfinder which is critical given their small size. Speed and accuracy of auto-focusing in low light is also another advantage.

A 50mm prime lens is also known as a natural lens as it lets you see the world as-is in a full-frame sensor dSLR.

## Image stabilisation

Among all the fancy features that are available in the lenses today, the one of most importance and impact is optical image stabilisation. Nikon calls it Vibration Reduction while Cannon calls it Image stabilisation, they both perform the same function and in almost similar ways.

Typically, in smaller digital cameras (read non-dSLRs) the image stabilisation is built into the camera, while in dSLRs, the image stabilisation